

Social Facts By Emile Durkheim

What is Social Facts ?

According to Emile Durkheim

Science or study of social facts is known as sociology

According to Emile Durkheim, a social fact is an abstract instance that shapes social behaviors. The idea behind this quote is that one should not center itself on the perceived consequences, but on what allows, forces, or drives those consequences. This can be social institutions, cultural determinants, etc.

For instances suicide is not a social fact on itself. Rather, certain aspects of a culture and of a way of life drive suicide, so the social fact is the communitarian nature of catholicism, or the lonesome competition resulting from a market economy, or the fatalistic melancholy of an oppressive and overly determinant authority.

What is Social Facts ?

Social facts in sociology was introduced by Emile Durkheim. Social facts are basically cultural norms and values and social structures present in a given society.

For example : Religion.

Social facts have the power to shape the conduct of individuals. It can control your actions and shape your behaviour. I'll explain with the help of an example. Take religion, every religion wants us to behave in a certain way. Different religions have different rituals for different occasions. It has specific norms that all followers need to comply to.

The meaning of social in 'social facts' is that their source is not in the individual, their substratum can be no other than society.

Social facts are believed by the society. Our behaviour is caused by the social facts.

Society is not just collection of an individuals. Society really exists a social fact can change the individual behaviour.

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Features of Social Facts

- 1) Social facts exist outside the individual.
- 2) Social facts have coercive power.
- 3) They must be studied as things and scientific method must be employed to study them.

Example of social facts

Marriage: There are certain norms in different societies related to marriage. For eg: Monogamy, Polygamy, Polyandre etc. When these are not followed people experience the coercive power of social facts.

Religion: Various religions have certain practices associated with them and the sociologist need to study them objectively

Why study social facts?

Because Durkheim sees two sort of them:

- The normal ones, that drive the maintenance of daily routines, orders, and social life.
- The Pathological ones, that drive consequences that might disrupt individual and collective wellbeing, and endanger the sustainability of a society.

The study of social facts ought to help find the later and prevent them.

Types of Social Facts

Two types of social facts are material and non-material social facts.

- Material social facts are features of society such as social structures and institutions.
- Nonmaterial social facts are social facts which do not have a material reality. They consist of features such as norms, values, and systems of morality.

Characteristics of Social Facts

- 1) Externality
- 2) Constraints
- 3) Generality
- 4) Independent